Lesson 13: Grammar: Adverbs, Past Tense, Comparatives and Superlatives

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 3.3: Grammar: Adverbs; 3.4: Grammar: Identifying the Past Tense; 3.5: Grammar: Comparative and Superlative Adjectives and Adverbs.

In this lesson

You learn what adverbs do, and you practice adverbs of frequency, manner and comment. You find regular and irregular past tense verbs in the Great Migration text from Lesson 12. Then you compare places with comparative and superlative adjectives and adverbs.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Find adverbs and say what they modify: a verb, an adjective, another adverb or a clause.
- Use adverbs of frequency, manner and comment in the usual position.
- Recognize regular (-ed) and irregular past tense verbs in a text.
- Form comparatives and superlatives with the correct spelling.
- Compare and recommend places with "than", "the most", "less" and "the least".

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
adverb	a word that gives more information about a verb, an adjective, another adverb or a clause	"San Diego has a very diverse population."
modify	to give more information about a word	"An adverb can modify a verb, a clause, an adjective, or another adverb."
adverb of frequency	an adverb that tells how often	"I always eat breakfast."
adverb of manner	an adverb that tells how	"Adverbs of manner answer the question of 'how.'"
comment adverb	an adverb that gives the speaker's opinion	"Fortunately, we arrived before the concert began."
regular verb	a verb that adds -ed (or -d) for the past	walk - walked; rake - raked
irregular verb	a verb that changes its spelling for the past	find - found; have - had

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
comparative	a form that compares two things	"Torrey Pines State Park is closer than Yosemite National Park."
superlative	a form that compares three or more things	"Of all the parks in Southern California, Torrey Pines is the best."
CVC	consonant + vowel + consonant at the end of a word	big - bigger; hot - hotter - hottest

Rules and explanations

What adverbs do

- An adverb modifies a verb ("always **speak**"), an adjective ("very **diverse**"), another adverb ("very **quickly**") or a whole clause ("Fortunately, **they are learning English**").
- Many adverbs end in -ly. You can often make an adverb from an adjective + -ly: quick - quickly. But not all adverbs end in -ly: fast, never, often.

Three kinds of adverbs

- **Frequency** (how often): always, usually, often / frequently, sometimes, occasionally, seldom / rarely, never (from most often to least often). We usually use them with simple present or simple past verbs. In the book's example, the adverb comes before the main verb: "I always eat breakfast."
- **Manner** (how): these modify verbs and usually come after the verb: "She walked quickly."
- **Comment** (the speaker's opinion): these usually come at the start of the sentence, followed by a comma: "Fortunately, we arrived before the concert began."

Past tense: regular and irregular verbs

- Regular verbs add -ed to the base form: walk - walked. If the base form ends in e, add only -d: rake - raked.
- Irregular verbs change their spelling: have - had, find - found. There is no one rule, so learn them by memory.
- Careful: some words end in -ed but are adjectives, not verbs ("I feel tired").

Comparatives (two things)

- One syllable: add -er: rich - richer, high - higher. Ends in -e: add -r: large - larger. Ends in CVC: double the last consonant: big - bigger.
- Two syllables ending in -y: drop the -y and add -ier: easy - easier, happy - happier.
- Other words with two or more syllables: more + word: more diverse, more difficult.
- Adverbs: one syllable + -er (faster); two or more syllables, including -ly adverbs: more + adverb (more slowly).
- Put "than" after the comparative: "Torrey Pines State Park is closer than Yosemite National Park."

Superlatives (three or more things)

- the + -est: the highest, the strangest, the fastest. -y words: the easiest, the earliest.
- the most + longer words and -ly adverbs: the most popular, the most quickly.
- Spelling is the same as for -er: strange - stranger - strangest; ugly - uglier - ugliest; hot - hotter - hottest.
- For a negative comparison, use less / the least: "Torrey Pines State Park is less crowded than Yosemite National Park." "Of all the parks in Southern California, Torrey Pines is the least crowded."

Irregular forms

Word	Comparative	Superlative
good / well	better	the best
bad / badly	worse	the worst
little	less	the least
much / many	more	the most
far	farther / further	the farthest / the furthest
early	earlier	the earliest

"Early" is an adjective and an adverb. It ends in -ly, but it uses -ier and -iest, not "more" and "most".

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - In Arabic, the same word form can mean "bigger" or "the biggest". In English you need two forms: "bigger than" for two things and "the biggest" for three or more.
> - Remember "the" before a superlative adjective: "Of all the parks in Southern California, Torrey Pines is the least crowded."

Practice

1. Find the adverbs. Find the adverb in each sentence. Which word or words does it modify?

- San Diego has a very diverse population.
- Immigrants to San Diego don't always speak English.
- Fortunately, they are learning English.
- The students in this class are learning English very quickly.

2. Why use adverbs? What do we learn from the second sentence in each pair?

- (a) Immigrants are learning English. / Fortunately, immigrants are learning English.
- (b) The students in this class are learning English. / The students in this class are learning English very quickly.

- (c) San Diego has nice beaches. / San Diego has incredibly nice beaches.

3. What is modified? What is the part of speech of the word or phrase in bold? very **diverse** · always **speak** · Fortunately, **they are learning English** · **are learning** very quickly · very **quickly**

Adverb bank (for exercises 4-7): incredibly, always, happily, angrily, quickly, fast, early, never, sometimes, often, usually, sadly, fortunately, seldom, rarely, delightedly, hungrily, basically, definitely, probably, possibly, too, unfortunately, luckily, certainly, hardly, quietly, frequently, occasionally

4. Endings. What is a common ending for many (but not all) of the adverbs in the bank?

5. Frequency. Which adverbs can complete this sentence to tell "how often"? *I* _____ *eat breakfast.*

6. Manner. Which adverbs can show how she walked or ate? *She walked* _____. *She ate* _____.

7. Comment. Which adverbs can show the writer's opinion? _____*, we arrived before the concert began.*

8. Find the past tense. Use the Great Migration text in 3.4 of your lesson material. (a) Find the regular past tense verbs (-ed). (b) Find three irregular past tense verbs.

9. Comparative adjectives. Which two nouns are compared? What is the comparative adjective? What word follows it?

- San Diego, CA is larger than El Cajon, CA.
- Black Mountain is higher than Mount Helix.

10. Comparative adverbs. Find the comparative adverb in each sentence.

- I like to go hiking, but I hike more slowly than my kids.
- African Americans moved to the north during the Great Migration because they could vote more freely there.
- If you want to sightsee in San Diego, take a car; cars travel faster than buses in San Diego.
- It takes longer to visit the zoo than to visit Balboa Park.

11. Superlatives. Find the superlative in each sentence.

- Cowles Mountain is the highest point in the city of San Diego.
- It is also the most popular mountain for hiking.
- On the other hand, Woodson Mountain is the best place to take a photo, because it has Potato Chip Rock.
- You can hike most easily at Torrey Pines State Beach.

12. Write the forms. Write the comparative and the superlative: dark, strange, ugly, hot, beautiful, good, bad, far, early, happily.

13. Make recommendations. Say your answers to your tutor, then write them.

- Compare two restaurants. Which one is better? Why?
- Recommend the most exciting activity for a family with kids. Explain why.

- What's the best place to see a movie in your city or area? Why?
- What sights do you recommend a tourist see when they visit? Compare two or three.
- Which city or area is the easiest for a new immigrant to move into? Why?

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me how often I do ten everyday things. I will answer with always, usually, often, sometimes, rarely or never. Correct the position of my adverbs."
- "Ask me what I did last weekend. Correct my past tense verbs, especially irregular verbs."
- "Let's compare two cities I know. Ask me one question at a time. I will answer with comparatives and superlatives."
- "Role-play: you are a tourist in my city. Ask me for recommendations: the best restaurant, the most exciting activity, the easiest way to travel."

Read aloud

- AD·verb
- AD·jec·tive
- com·PAR·a·tive
- su·PER·la·tive
- REG·u·lar
- ir·REG·u·lar
- FOR·tu·nate·ly
- oc·CA·sion·al·ly
- ma·JES·tic
- POP·u·lar

Watch online

- Adverbs, the book's interactive slides: https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/e/2PACX-1vQveA3XnnUMuZrEwEw785QCW9I075bisCZtaiT19Ii87AUNSzaSup4sY2xwpE9WFZAM1ROY8PAyIk50/embed
- Comparatives and superlatives, the book's interactive slides: https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/e/2PACX-1vQzrATluCrsV3D_CzE7-0_MUPn8cfF4jTRgpspb_ei6iLonHte4hn3uEguL8WdQdcZ4cjZEyLcgJS7e/embed
- Video, What Are Adverbs?: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_txnezQ12c0
- Video, What is an Adverb?: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L0USJe44yS4
- Video, comparatives and superlatives: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=U2DxNgQqDgQ
- Practice quiz, comparative adjectives: https://www.englishclub.com/grammar/adjectives-comparative.htm
- Practice quiz, comparative adverbs: https://www.englishclub.com/grammar/adverbs-comparative.php

Answer key

1. (book) "very" modifies "diverse"; "always" modifies "speak"; "Fortunately" modifies "they are learning English"; "very quickly" modifies "are learning".

2. (book) (a) the author's opinion; (b) how the students are learning; (c) that the beaches are not just nice but incredibly nice.

3. (book) adjective; verb; clause; verb; adverb. So an adverb can modify a verb, a clause, an adjective or another adverb.

4. -ly (book). Adverbs in the bank without -ly: always, fast, never, sometimes, often, seldom, too.

5. (book) always, often, frequently, usually, sometimes, occasionally, seldom, rarely, never.

6. (book) happily, angrily, quickly, fast, sadly, delightedly, hungrily, quietly.

7. (book) incredibly, sadly, fortunately, basically, unfortunately, luckily, certainly. ("Happily", meaning "fortunately", is also possible.)

8. (a) moved (5 times), helped, worked (3 times), faced, earned, experienced (3 times), permitted (permit + t + ed). (b) Any three: had, found (2 times), was (3 times, one in "was called"), were, did (2 times). Careful: "overcrowded" and "crowded" end in -ed, but here they are adjectives.

9. (book) "San Diego, CA" and "El Cajon, CA": larger. "Black Mountain" and "Mount Helix": higher. The word after it is "than".

10. (book) more slowly than; more freely; faster than; longer ... than.

11. (book) the highest; the most popular; the best; most easily.

12. darker, the darkest; stranger, the strangest; uglier, the ugliest; hotter, the hottest; more beautiful, the most beautiful; better, the best; worse, the worst; farther / further, the farthest / the furthest; earlier, the earliest; more happily, the most happily.

13. (example answers) The small cafe near my house is better than the big restaurant downtown, because the food is fresher and the waiters work more quickly. Visiting the zoo is the most exciting activity for a family with kids, because children love animals.

My notes